

NOTES

Special School Committee Meeting: FY23 Budget

Monday, May 9, 2022 6:00 PM Via Zoom

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Roll: Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: 7/0 all present

Presentation Regarding the Fiscal Year 2023 Medford Public Schools Operating Budget Focusing on Strategic Priorities Concerning Equitable Supports for High Needs/Most Vulnerable Students, Instructional Technology, COVID-19 Recovery and Organizational Structure.

[Link to Slides:](#)

- Asst. Superintendent of Finance & Operations David Murphy

Supt. Edouard-Vincent: Today is the kick off for the Budget process. Mr. Murphy has spent a lot of time cataloging and organizing the data?

David Murphy: I will be sharing a deck with you all. Tonight is the first formal budget meeting. As SC is aware, we have been updating you quarterly and expressing the budgetary priorities and challenges we are going to face coming into this fiscal year. As we discussed on May 2nd, given that the district is in the midst of negotiations with 9 collective bargaining units, that is a significant variable that poses a lot of uncertainty going into this process. We still have an obligation to pursue our educational objectives putting student outcomes at the center of all strategic priorities.

Whenever we talk about the budget, there is some redundancy as we go through the sequence. The budget is an opportunity for the community to see how the organization is functioning.

Slide one: Budget process

The administrators completed a survey expressing their priorities especially how they adhere to the strategic plan. There is uncertainty as to what the contribution will be but we are fortunate to have some one time ESSER funds but we need to work out how we determine which budget the priorities land under. We don't want to create deficits - things we won't be able to fund in the future. The superintendent makes a recommendation to the School Committee and then that will go to the City Council and the Mayor. As the school administration, we need to prepare for all contingencies. Priorities are based on facts and truthful needs of our students but we understand that the schools are but one part of the Medford City budget.

Currently negotiating with 9 collective bargaining units.

One goal is to increase wages to remain competitive while ensuring sustainability. We do not want to cause structural deficits that will cause problems for MPS in years ahead.

FY 23 Priorities:

Critical Priorities: SEL/mental health supports, Vocational expansion of programming, reduction of fee based services, summer and extended day programming

Personnel Priorities: Math coaches, interventionists, library staffing/support, pay equity, recruitment and retention of support staff (paraprofessionals and substitutes).

Technology/Curriculum Priorities: Backfilling/replacement system, Lexia Core 5, Math Investigations III, Differentiated materials (augmented technology)

Professional Learning Priorities: Lead Teacher Models, Restorative Practices, Student/Family engagement feedback cycles, Implementation of Literacy and Math platforms

Equity/Student Support Priorities: Implicit bias training, UDL, family engagement and outreach, training on inclusive best practices

The first 1.1 million dollars are spoken for due to fixed personnel costs. There are other fixed costs like transportation, utilities, special education outplacements, subscriptions, custodial services and maintenance and translation services.

We are also hoping to add 2 to 4 Math Coaches, ideally one per each elementary school. It will be a capacity issue as to how many we end up hiring.

Does anyone have any questions so far?

\$69.9m currently in the FY23 developing budget.

Goes up to \$71.1 million when including the fixed costs (with a 2% COLA). We know that our students are presenting with needs that will be addressed by Paul Teixeira, Stacey Schulman, Avery Hines and Joan Bowen later tonight. Our flexibility is limited but the severity of the needs of our students coming out of the pandemic cannot wait.

The school district is not making a request of \$80 million dollars. It is not a spending spree but it is a look at our students' needs. Theme for tonight is providing equitable supports to our most vulnerable students. Ms. Laden is also here and can speak to some library/technology enhancements.

Categorization of potential items. Positions categorized as A need to be committed to and in the Operating Budget. Items classified as B need to be hired but we may be able to use other funding. It is not the case that we will be able to add all these positions in FY23.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: are you including all these numbers in the \$71.1K?

Dave M: If it is just Category A it would be \$71.4K. A and B would be \$72K.

Paul Teixeira, Director of English Learners: Need for additional EL teachers to serve our newcomers at the Elementary Schools.

Sharing slides:

Enrollment numbers are fluid throughout the year. We are up to 577 students today which is the highest that Medford has had. These are mostly newcomers requiring the highest level of EL services. With that said, I predict the numbers will continue to grow. We have increased by 62 students since January. The borders closed last year so we are getting 2 years of students in a single year. Because they are coming in at all different times of the year, they will remain newcomers next year as well. We do not have a Kindergarten newcomer program because best practice doesn't call for doing so. We have 86 EL students in Kindergarten this year (44 of them are newcomers). I am going to need another first grade newcomer classroom. I see that our numbers will continue to grow which is why I am asking for 4 more EL teachers.

Melanie McLaughlin: Can we get a copy of the powerpoint presentations?

Dave Murphy: Yes you will

The list in front of you and those in the next slide are an articulation of the global personnel needs of the school district so that we can drill down to the objectives stated earlier. We do not expect that they will all be funded.

Jenny Graham: Can you go back to the categorization slide?

Stacey Schulman: Director of Counseling and Behavioral Health

School Adjustment counselors are school social workers

School counselors: Guidance counselors: academic planning and 504s

School Psychologists: Counseling individual and group, assessments

BCBAs: Work on behavior plans

Behavior Specialists on the elementary level.

There is an increase in needs for mental health care. Children are experiencing more challenges than ever before. We need more staffing to address these needs such as crisis management. We see students needing more care and support throughout the day.

Melanie McLaughlin: FBAs: functional behavioral assessments.

Stacey Schulman: Any member of our staff can perform the FBAs in the school setting.

Needs:

3 School Adjustment counselors

1. Brooks- move from 1 to 2 school adjustment counselors
2. Reduce the split positions (3 elementary schools have split positions): goal is to have a person remain in one building 5 days a week.

McGlynn ES would go from 1.6 to 2.0

MES would go from 1.6 to 2.0

Roberts would go from 1.4 to 2.0

Looking to MMS to 2 full time adjustment counselors.

Not included in the budget is a dph funded school adjustment counselor at the MHS level.

David Murphy; There is a bit of inconsistency in the way we speak of the grants. The DPH grant Stacey mentioned. We will prioritize this in our budget for 2023. The grant gives us time to be able to migrate from the Esser budget to the operating budget.

Melanie McLaughlin: Andrews and MHS/MVTHS ratios?

Dave Murphy: School adjustment counselors are category b. We may have to resort to ESSER funding to do it. The career counselor position is category D. It is a priority but we may not have the immediate capacity to address it.

Stacey Schulman: Career Counseling position: I would like to restore this position. Now that the students are going back to more activities, we need to have someone track the community service hours, build relationships with the community, more college visits, assisting with local job placement and managing dual enrollment programs at Bunker Hill and Ben Franklin. We would like to be able to increase the dual enrollment opportunities. We need to better connect our students with the community particularly with scholarship pursuits, school counseling workshops, scheduling caseloads, test scheduling.

Sharon Hays: My question is on the school adjustment counselors. Did we talk about the Andrews?

Stacey Schulman: This year we added an adjustment counselor so they are well staffed.

Sharon Hays: So everyone gets bumped up to 2.0?

Stacey Schulman: Yes.

Jenny Graham: In the past budget books, the school populations were listed. It would be helpful if we can see the enrollment sets in the budget books. Ms. Galusi, do you have any rundown on the size of the elementary schools?

Suzanne Galusi: Brooks and the Roberts are the highest. Then McGlynn. Missituk is the lowest.

Melanie McLaughlin: I also want people who are watching to know that there are ratios of most vulnerable students. There are nuances in the populations at each school with different needs.

Jenny Graham: I do think that it is an excellent point. I am hoping that the budget books will also show the sizes of the subgroups in each building? And what the staffing is at each building.

Melanie McLaughlin: I would like to add to that this can also be checked on google dese school district profiles. Visuals are very helpful and they are very helpful on the DESE cover pages for each district.

Dave Murphy: I agree. The specialized programming in each building shows how budgets come to life and gives the community a peak inside the schools. Thank you for the suggestion.

Avery Hines: Health Services Department

3 staffing requests in different categories or priority:

Currently 14.6 full time nurses plus 3 float nurses covered by ESSER funding.

The .6 position is at Curtis Tufts.

The nurse at the Curtis Tufts has seen 578 visits this year - large increase. Looking at the visits, there are many non-COVID related visits. Every student deserves a nurse every day. There are chronic health conditions the students have. We have to think about acuity. One complex health situation can take all day of a nurse's time. The population at the Curtis Tufts can change any day. We get calls all the time if there is a need. That is why we are requesting a 1.0 nurse at the Curtis Tufts(category D - this is an addition of .4 not a full position increase).

We would also like a registration nurse. We are noticing that the students coming from other countries have many more needs and require care coordination. They often need to be set up with health insurance and a doctor. Many have chronic health conditions we need to care for.

We would like the retention of a 1.0 float nurse. We are still feeling the effects of the pandemic in the health services dept. Vaccinations to track, testing, long covid cases. (new onsets of diabetes and seizure disorders).

Dave Murphy: The only other immediate personnel issue is Special Education. Always the case with specialized transportation and tuitions.

Joan Bowen, Director of Pupil Services:

Additional High School Special Education Teacher; Increasing number of students with disabilities. Looking at the current IEPs, schedule requirements, and enrollments we identify how many sections are required. We are finding that more students are requiring sub separate learning. The Teacher would be employed as a fourth TLP teacher. We have an increasing enrollment for Grade 9 (going from 61 this year to 80 next year). Special education rules place limits on numbers of students who can be in a classroom.

Melanie McLaughlin: Can you speak to why you are seeing the need for sub separate settings?

Joan Bown: It is more therapeutic in nature. Smaller student ratios required. There is an increase in anxiety.

Melanie McLaughlin: Is this categorization A or using Esser since it is related to social emotional learning?

Dave Murphy: Because it is staffing reflective of our priorities in Special education requirements to meet least restrictive learning environments, we would look into ESSER if we cannot meet it. It is a need that will transcend the COVID period. The categorization is more of an art than a science.

Questions for Ms. Bowen regarding Special Education??

Melanie McLaughlin: I want to reiterate these are top priorities not the entire department list?

Dave Murphy: Significant priorities that are changes from FY 22 to FY 23. We will be talking tomorrow night and next week so please relay your questions to committee members so we can address each item.

Slide 14: Technology, infrastructure, PD, Supplies

We will talk more about technology tomorrow but Molly if you would like to touch upon the IPAD investment and assistive technology?

Joan Bowen: Assistive technology in the classroom helps to ensure that students have the same opportunities as all students. Assistive technology is needed for in district and out of district programming. IPADs are used for communication purposes. We have specific apps on the IPAD s for the students. It could be communication apps such as touchchat or proloquo. They can touch a picture and the word is read for them. We also need the additional chargers and warranties that accompany the IPADs.

Melanie McLaughlin: Disability Awareness Training looks like a high priority. It is the next line item.

Joan Bowen: Two years or so ago, we started a Disability Awareness workshop but we would like to expand it in the district either to hire an outside consultant to help us with this or use internal staff to assist staff member with proper vocabulary and understanding of accommodations and modifications and how we can meet the needs of all our students.

Melanie McLaughlin: The disability curriculum?

Joan Bowen: That is separate.

David Murphy: Other technology initiatives. Makerspace might qualify for one time criteria and may fit ESSER guidelines. We would not necessarily include it in the operating budget but we do know it is a priority to provide these opportunities. Refurbishment of locker room space - some space was used for storage during the pandemic and the refurbishment is a district priority. Hopefully we can invest a modest amount to refurbish the locker rooms to bring them back to a more presentable state.

Molly Laden - Technology:

There are a few items on our list that we are lacking in: ceiling mounted projectors in about 40 classrooms. We are looking at setting up projecting systems such as interactive panels on the wall. Less labor intensive installation. Will take \$90k to put in interactive flat panel displays mostly in K-5 (two in science classrooms in middle schools). Verizon and City funds funded our maker space in the high school. Now that we can have shared spaces again, we are bringing them online again. We hope to bring them to the other schools as well but we would need certified librarians in each building.

Dave Murphy: Next slide. Last year we spoke about regression in music progression due to not being in school. Along with the Makerspace, we are looking at using ESSER

funding for music. We are looking to be able to issue subgrants to different departments. Dr. Ricciardelli expressed a need to restock our music instrument inventory. It would be an estimated \$20K investment. We need to avoid situations where there are not enough instruments for students to participate in a music program. We had a successful music summer camp program last summer and we have scheduled it again for this August. On the arts side of the organization, in order to think about culture and climate issues, we are looking at using ESSER funding for arts programs and community art displays. They are modest investments but reflect the broader goals.

Melanie McLaughlin: Regarding the art programming and instruction, I want to ask Ms. Bowen and others, what are we doing to meet specialized instruction needs. We have more inclusion opportunities in the specials like art and music but families have spoken about the lack of differentiation in instruction in these areas. Is any of this programmatic element being addressed?

Dave Murphy: On the musical instruments side, this challenge was specifically called out as something that needs to be addressed.

Joan Bowen: We need to look at supporting our most vulnerable students in our elective courses so every student can access music. We do have a music teacher with a special education background at the high school and I want to look at how things are being modified there. How do we carry that over to the middle school levels as well?

Transportation and Lunch:

Transportation initiative this year to provide transportation outside of 2 miles costing us \$9k a month. We have the ESSER funding to keep this going in FY 23 if the SC agrees to do that?

Lunch: we at the moment are looking at the revolving account with our school lunch program and hope to have a surplus. Because lunches have been covered by the federal government, it is difficult for us to determine the costs of free lunch district wide. We understand that it is a priority of the committee but we can't condone it right now. Hopefully it will get approved on Beacon Hill. At the district level, it poses too much uncertainty.

Paul Ruseau: It is the current policy of the SC that we will provide it. Absent a school committee member putting it on the agenda to reverse it, it will be free.

Dave Murphy: I appreciate the intent of the policy that was adopted. From a principled perspective, the administration agrees with it. It was introduced on the floor and I was asked to speak to it extemporaneously. At the time it was afforded to all school districts across the country. I have a responsibility to report to the committee that it has an

uncertain financial implication. Given the budget we are trying to develop, it takes on a level of risk that is imprudent.

Paul Ruseau: I want to discount what you are trying to do. Either we follow policy or not. I don't want to propose a policy that you will not follow when you need to. We put wiggle room in the language for the discipline policy. My opinion based on the vote of 7 members.

Dave Murphy: We are not charging for lunch right now. If you want to have us not charge next year, there will be a cost associated with that. Hopefully the legislature take it out of our hands. I can't even tell you what the cost will be.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: I hope the state comes through for us but it could be a million plus dollars.

Sharon Hays: My understanding is that it is currently in the state budget to cover it for next year.

Dave Murphy: Yes it is in the proposed budget but the budget is not a done deal.

Melanie McLaughlin: We won't know that until July 1 if it is passed in the Governor's budget.

Dave Murphy: it reaffirms the point there is a lot of uncertainty with this.

Jenny Graham: If I recall back even before the pandemic when we were talking about a pilot and a part of that was to track participation to see if we would qualify for a program somewhere. I think you say we can't track this? Why can't we size this?

Dave Murphy: Participation at the free rate could be different than what it would be if we were to charge for it. If the committee wants us to attempt to do this, we can come back with a projection. I will be conservative with that projection and we can put it to the committee for consideration. Last year the food service budget ended up with a half a million dollar deficit.

Jenny Graham: The city signed a hunger free pledge. The task force is trying to make sure politicians do what they can to keep Medford hunger free. What I have relayed to them, it is all dependent on what we will get from the city. Food vs. salaries for administrators is not a conversation we like to have. We do need to understand what it will cost.

Dave Murphy: There is no one in the administration that wants to charge for lunch. We

don't want a school system littered with user generated fees. Either the city can appropriate more money for this priority or not? I feel the need to flag this particular initiative.

Jenny Graham: I understand and appreciate that. This committee needs to get information on the value of providing free lunch to those who may not want to qualify under the free lunch program. When every kid isn't hungry, then every kid can focus on learning. Can we find someone from the food security task force to see how this fits in with the proclamation to make Medford hunger free.

Dave Murphy: We can do that. I want it known from the outset, I don't even know what the request would be.

Paul Ruseau: I understand that there is no one who wants to charge kids for food. The drop in participation will happen when we start charging. The effects of the pandemic are not done and there are many people who don't want to pose a security risk by applying for free lunch. Can ESSER funds be used?

Dave Murphy: It might but without an unknown price tag, it makes it difficult. It would make us pump this issue down the road a few years. If every district does that, the legislators have less incentive to do anything about it.

Paul Ruseau: I would like to move towards hunger free Medford. It was already voted on by the school committee.

Dave Murphy: We will try to address this with as much specificity as we can. Final two slides summing up where we have landed with our priorities. We will continue to communicate as to the fluctuations that take place between now and when we make the request. With category A only we will land on a \$71.4K request. With A & B, we land on \$72K.

Tomorrow we will talk more about staffing issues and the vocational school and challenges facing our specific school communities. We ran a bit over tonight. We will also pick it up at our regular meeting on May 16. Any final questions?

Paul Ruseau: I didn't see columns including the other categories. We should have that.

Dave Murphy: One clarifying point, these are all priorities worthy of public discussion. They will not all make it into the Supt.'s recommendation to you. We need to look at it as one cohesive piece of information.

Paul Ruseau: With the new math curriculum, math coaches are level C and D. Purchasing something without fidelity is not responsible. I want the community to know

that when we land on a number, there was a way for us to have funded those. It is the awkwardness of having the mayor as the SC chair. We have one responsibility as a school committee - to focus on what the schools need to the exclusion of the other stuff. It is the only reasonable thing.

Sharon Hays: Question about process: is there a chance to ask questions about some of the things tonight if they come up later?

Dave Murphy: Yes. There will be more time for questions tomorrow. Assuming people do not want to go through the whole list again, we can address them tomorrow and also at the meeting on Monday night. As for the sequence, once the request goes to the city government, the SC has to vote to adopt the budget. That will be another opportunity to flush it out.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Thank you for the presentation to all the department heads. Meeting tomorrow at 7PM after the McGlynn open house.

Dave Murphy: We look forward to seeing you tomorrow night.

Paul Ruseau: Motion to adjourn.

Jenny Graham: Thank you to the team who put this together. I really like this concise format over what we did in past years. It gets us quickly to where we need to be. I second the motion to adjourn.

ROLL: Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: 7/0
Meeting is adjourned at 8:42PM.